

The Dream



POEM TEXT

- 1 Dear love, for nothing less than thee
- 2 Would I have broke this happy dream;
3 It was a theme
- 4 For reason, much too strong for fantasy,
- 5 Therefore thou wak'dst me wisely; yet
- 6 My dream thou brok'st not, but continuedst it.
- 7 Thou art so true that thoughts of thee suffice
- 8 To make dreams truths, and fables histories;
- 9 Enter these arms, for since thou thought'st it best,
- 10 Not to dream all my dream, let's do the rest.
- 11 As lightning, or a taper's light,
- 12 Thine eyes, and not thy noise, wak'd me;
13 Yet I thought thee
- 14 (For thou lovest truth) an angel, at first sight;
- 15 But when I saw thou sawest my heart,
- 16 And knew'st my thoughts, beyond an angel's art,
- 17 When thou knew'st what I dreamt, when thou knew'st
when
- 18 Excess of joy would wake me, and cam'st then,
- 19 I must confess, it could not choose but be
- 20 Profane, to think thee anything but thee.
- 21 Coming and staying show'd thee, thee,
- 22 But rising makes me doubt, that now
23 Thou art not thou.
- 24 That love is weak, where fear's as strong as he;
- 25 'Tis not all spirit, pure, and brave,
- 26 If mixture it of fear, shame, honour have.
- 27 Perchance, as torches which must ready be,
- 28 Men light and put out, so thou deal'st with me;
- 29 Thou cam'st to kindle, goest to come; then I
- 30 Will dream that hope again, but else would die.



SUMMARY

My darling, I wouldn't have awakened from my wonderful dream for anything less than you. My dream was so intense and believable that it hardly felt like a dream at all. As such, it was wise of you to wake me up. Yet you didn't actually end my dream—you kept it going. You're so very real that merely

thinking of you makes dreams come true and turns fairy tales to histories. Come into my arms. Given that you thought it was better for me not to finish dreaming my dream, let's make it real and play out the conclusion.

Much as a lightning flash or a candle might wake one up, the light of your eyes, not the sound you were making, woke me. At first I thought (to tell you the truth, since you love the truth) that you were an angel. But when I saw that you could see into my heart and my dreams—a power that mere angels don't have; when I saw that you knew what I was dreaming, that you knew exactly when the overflowing intensity of my pleasure was about to wake me up, and that you arrived at exactly that moment: I have to say, with all this evidence, it would be sacrilegious of me to think that you were anything but yourself.

Your arrival and your choice to stay here proved to me that you're you. But now you're getting up, and that makes me worry that you're *not* you. It's a weak love indeed that's not stronger than fear. Love isn't a thing made of pure spirit if it's mixed up with fear, shame, and worries about your reputation. Perhaps you're doing what people do when they light a torch once, then put it out, so it's easier to light up again later. If that's the case, you came to set me aflame; now you're leaving to put me out only so that you can come back and light me up again later. So I'll return to my dream in the hopes that it will soon come true; otherwise, I'd die.



THEMES



FANTASY VS. REALITY

"The Dream" explores the tension between the ideal and the real, particularly in matters of love. The poem's speaker is awakened from a dream of the lady he's smitten with by the lady he's smitten with. This act delights him, making him feel as if there's no distinction between the world of fantasy and the world of reality. A sense that a glorious dream has come true, this poem suggests, is one of the delights of love, but also one of its risks—because reality can't always coincide so perfectly with fantasy as one might, well, fantasize.

When his beloved wakes him up, the poem's speaker is happy to see her but not surprised. Her arrival is just the continuation of the dream he was having about her—a dream that was already "much too strong for fantasy." The dream, in other words, was *real* to the speaker.

This lady is "so true," the speaker continues, that mere "thoughts" of her are enough to "make dreams truths, and fables histories." She doesn't simply bring the speaker's dream to life by happening to be there when he wakes up, but by

animating his dreams with her real presence. In other words, the speaker's passionate love for this lady collapses the barrier between dream and reality. She's the realest, most solid thing in the world to him, waking or sleeping.

That's all well and good until the lady starts to do something the speaker would never dream of her doing: she appears to be about to get up and leave without "do[ing] the rest" of the speaker's dream with him. The speaker objects with this brain-twister: "Coming and staying show'd thee, thee, / But rising makes me doubt, that now / Thou art not thou." In other words: *When you came here and stayed here, you proved that you were yourself. But now that you're getting up, I begin to doubt that you're really you.* When the real, live lady's behavior differs from the dream lady's, then, the speaker sees the divergence as a sign that the living lady might be the false one! Here, the dream takes on a *deeper* reality than reality: fantasy, to the speaker, becomes "truer" than reality.

This idea has a few complex implications. On one level, this is a tongue-in-cheek poem about the disappointment of discovering that one's beloved *isn't* identical to fantasies about them (and about the efforts one might go to in order to keep from admitting that this is the case—as when the speaker imagines that his lady must just be frustrating him now in order to better satisfy them both later on). On another level, the poem is making a claim that a love so strong it blurs the boundaries between fantasy and reality has its own kind of truth, one that can bring tremendous joy to those who honor it.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-30



LOVE AND DESIRE

In "The Dream" as in many of John Donne's poems, depicts romantic and sexual love as holy. The poem's speaker awakes from an intimate dream of his beloved only to find that this woman is indeed right there before him. He says that when she first woke him up, right before his dream reached its climax, he thought she must be an angel. He then expands beyond this moment of [cliché](#)d flattery, however. Because his beloved woke him up at the exact moment before his dream reached its conclusion in an "excess of joy" (that is, an orgasm), he reasons, she must have been able to see into his mind and read his thoughts. And that's "beyond an angel's art": that is, angels don't have the power to read minds, according to the best Renaissance theology. She is, then, *above the angels*.

The daring implication is that the beloved is close to God. The speaker doesn't spell this idea out explicitly, but he nonetheless makes it very clear that he sees his beloved as divine when he tells her that it would be "profane" (or sacrilegious) to mistake her for anyone but herself, even for an angel.

The speaker's passionate love, then, makes this lady seem divine to him. This is the crux of his argument for why he and she should "do the rest" of what his dream showed him (that is, go to bed with him): his beloved's interruption of his dream, he says, reveals that his beloved is divine, that their love is divine, and that any sex they happened to have could only be divine, too. A profound sexual love, to this speaker, is a thing of the "spirit," a "pure," "brave" (or glorious), and transformative expression of the sacred.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 1-20



SEXUAL SHAME AND HONOR

This poem's plot is, at its root, an old and common one in English verse: the story of a man trying to persuade a woman to sleep with him, potentially against her better judgment. For women of Donne's era, sex was a fraught issue. An intense cultural double standard held that women should remain chaste until marriage, where men could do essentially whatever they liked. It's no wonder, then, that the poem's speaker gets the sense his beloved might have some worries about "fear," "shame," and "honour."

This poem's speaker tries to work around these worries and prohibitions in a novel way. Where other passionate poets have coaxed their ladies into bed with the idea that [life is short](#) and people should have fun [while they're young](#), this speaker makes a grander point about sexual love. "That love is weak, where fear's as strong as he," he says: in other words, any love that can be conquered by fear isn't much of a love at all. And he thinks better of his lady (whom he sees as an embodiment of divine "truth," loving her so much that she seems near to God) than to imagine that fear might make up any part of her love. True love without fear, he goes on, is "all spirit, pure, and brave": intimacy is an act, that is, of unadulterated ("pure") and glorious ("brave") *spirituality*, a way for lovers to touch the divine. (That point is only strengthened by Donne's deployment of a common Renaissance pun here: "spirit" might mean "semen" as well as "soul.")

This poem thus argues against sexual shame, restriction, and taboo by suggesting that pure sexual love couldn't possibly be wrong for a true lover, male or female. Sex between true lovers, here, is no defilement, but an approach to the divine. The only meaningful sexual shame would be in fearing and evading such divinity.

Where this theme appears in the poem:

- Lines 21-26



LINE-BY-LINE ANALYSIS

LINES 1-6

*Dear love, for nothing less than thee
 Would I have broke this happy dream;
 It was a theme
 For reason, much too strong for fantasy,
 Therefore thou wak'dst me wisely; yet
 My dream thou brok'st not, but continuedst it.*

"The Dream" begins at the moment a dream ends—a wonderful dream. The speaker addresses his "dear love," the lady who has just woken him up, telling her that she's the only person for whom he's willing to wake from the "happy dream" he was lost in moments ago. That's because she's the only person who, in waking him, could "continue[]" the dream: it was she herself, in other words, that he was dreaming of.

And in waking him, she seems to have done the right thing. This dream, he tells her, was a "theme / For reason, much too strong for fantasy." In other words, this dream was so intense and believable that it didn't feel like a dream at all but rather like something that was really happening. More than that, it was a vision that *should* be experienced with the "reason" of the waking, conscious mind, not in the airy, insubstantial realm of "fantasy."

For this reason, the speaker tells his lady, it was "wise[]" of her to awaken him. That's because, in doing so, she was putting fantasy and reality into the right balance. This dream of her *seemed* real, *should* be real, indeed somehow *was* real; now, the speaker hopes, its reality will be borne out in the waking world.

In these first lines, this poem might seem as if it's paying a pretty standard-issue compliment: *You*, the speaker tells this lady, *are the woman of my dreams*. But John Donne will not leave that compliment unexamined. Rather, across the course of this twisty poem, he will explore what it actually *means* to love someone so much that they seem like a dream come true: a situation in which figuring out what's real and what's fantasy will become a complicated matter.

At the poem's outset, take a moment to notice the rhythm of the verse. Each of this poem's stanzas will be 10 lines long. And each of the stanzas will begin with a five-line passage whose lines abruptly and surprisingly change length:

- The first two lines of each stanza are in [iambic tetrameter](#): lines of four iambs, metrical feet with a da-DUM rhythm, as in "Dear **love**, | for **noth-** | ing **less** | than **thee**"
- The third line is an abrupt, short line of iambic dimeter—just two iambs, "It **was** | a **theme**"
- The fourth line is iambic pentameter—five iambs, "For **rea-** | son, **much** | too **strong** | for **fan-** | ta **sy**."
- Line five drops back into iambic tetrameter.

- Then a steadier rhythm kicks in: the remaining five lines of the stanza are all in iambic pentameter.

In this way, every stanza starts with a dancing, nimble passage, then resolves into a steadier rhythm. These split stanzas might suggest the two worlds this poem unites (or hopes to unite): the world of fantasy and the world of reality.

LINES 7-10

*Thou art so true that thoughts of thee suffice
 To make dreams truths, and fables histories;
 Enter these arms, for since thou thought'st it best,
 Not to dream all my dream, let's do the rest.*

The speaker has praised his lady for knowing she should wake him up from a dream of her that was "much too strong for fantasy." Now, he makes a stronger, stranger claim, telling her:

Thou art so true that thoughts of thee suffice
 To make dreams truths, and fables histories;

In other words, this lady is so very "true"—so deeply real, somehow—that even a thought of her is enough to make a dream come true or to turn a fairy tale into a fact. The idea here isn't simply that the speaker was delighted to wake up and discover the very woman he was dreaming about happened to be there. It's that this lady's presence in his dream was, in some important way, *already real*.

In this speaker's eyes, then, there's something special about this lady. Even a thought or a dream of her is realer than real, more substantial than actual reality. On one level, this is a downright worshipful attitude: the lady seems to have an almost divine power, visiting the speaker in his dreams as an angel might visit a saint. For that matter, readers who have been deeply in love might recognize the feeling that one's beloved is somehow realer, brighter, more *solid* somehow than other people.

But the idea that the lady was as real in the speaker's dreams as she is real beside him now also opens up earthier possibilities. "Enter these arms," the speaker invites her; since she decided this was the moment to interrupt his dream, he feels, the two of them should clearly "do the rest" of that dream, finishing what the dream started.

Inviting the lady to enter his embrace (and therefore his bed), the speaker makes it clear that this dream of his was apparently a sexual one—and one that hadn't reached its conclusion when the lady woke him up. His suggestion that the dream-lady is just as real as the living lady thus has a handy implication for him: *You and I have already gotten started*, he is essentially saying, *so we might as well finish doing what we were doing!* (And notice the speaker's earthy language here: his suggestion that the couple "do the rest" of the dream made some later editors blush so much that they amended the blunt "do" to the more tasteful "act.")

As is so often the case in John Donne's love poetry, the sublime and the sexual wrap tightly around each other here. This is a poem about a man who is so deeply in love that his beloved seems like a living dream (and his dreams of her like realities); it's also a poem about a man who very much wants to persuade a woman to sleep with him.

LINES 11-14

*As lightning, or a taper's light,
Thine eyes, and not thy noise, wak'd me;
Yet I thought thee
(For thou lovest truth) an angel, at first sight;*

As the second stanza begins, the speaker backtracks, returning to the moment that his beloved woke him up. She made no noise as she entered his room; she didn't wake him in any way so clumsy as that. Rather, the sheer luminosity of her eyes broke into his dreams. The speaker makes this point through a pair of striking [similes](#). The lady's eyes, he says, worked like "lightning, or a taper's light." In other words, they awoke him as surely as a lightning flash or candlelight might.

There's a striking distance between those two kinds of light. The white shock of lightning and the soft orange glow of candlelight might both wake a sleeper up, but in such different ways: the lightning suddenly and by surprise, the candlelight gradually and gently. By bringing both these images into play, the speaker suggests that his lady's gaze has both of these qualities. There's an awe-inspiring flashing power in her eyes, but a warm softness, too. Awakened by the light of his beloved's eyes, the speaker says, he thought for a moment that his beloved must be an angel: a gorgeous divine being arriving at his bedside, eyes aglow.

LINES 15-20

*But when I saw thou sawest my heart,
And knew'st my thoughts, beyond an angel's art,
When thou knew'st what I dreamt, when thou knew'st when
Excess of joy would wake me, and cam'st then,
I must confess, it could not choose but be
Profane, to think thee anything but thee.*

When his lady first awoke him, the speaker claimed, he thought she must be an angel. Yet she couldn't possibly be an angel, he goes on, because she has powers "beyond an angel's art"—beyond those an angel possesses.

The proof? She seems to have been able to see into his mind and know what he was dreaming about. If she hadn't been able to read his dream, the speaker asks, how else would she have known to wake him up at the exact moment before his powerful dream came to its natural conclusion in an "excess of joy" (that is, in an orgasm)?

Donne was a passionate Christian—and "passionate" really is the word. His love poetry is full of God; his religious poetry is full of sex. For Donne, the flesh and the spirit were intimate

companions. Here, in characteristic fashion, Donne's speaker thus romances his beloved using a point of theology derived from the medieval scholar-saint Thomas Aquinas. According to Aquinas, angels didn't have the power to look into human minds; only God could do that. At the *very least*, then, the speaker's beloved is *above the angels* here; she has a divine power usually only attributed to no one less than the Almighty. And she's using her divine power to keep the speaker from having an orgasm in his sleep.

The speaker doubles down, too: he declares that it would be "profane" to believe that his beloved was anyone but herself. Even believing that she's an angel would be a sacrilegious understatement of her true power.

This new idea raises the poem to [hyperbolic](#) heights. The speaker has already suggested that his lady is magical; now he's suggesting she's *divine* (or divinely inspired at the least), and the proof is in her ability to interrupt his dream at the moment of climax. The implication is that there must be something sacred in the sex the two of them should now be having to finish out that dream.

Two contradictory things are happening at the same moment here:

- The speaker is shamelessly flattering this woman with hyperbolic praise in order to convince her to "do the rest" with him.
- The speaker is sincerely telling this woman that he loves her so much that she has become holy in his eyes. She is truer and realer and greater than an angel to him; she's next to God, and Godly power shines through her.

The shape of these lines supports this audacious idea. Listen to the drumroll of [repetitions](#):

But when I **saw** thou **sawest** my heart,
And **knew'st** my thoughts, beyond an angel's art,
When thou **knew'st** what I dreamt, **when** thou
knew'st when
Excess of joy would wake me, and cam'st then,

The [diacope](#) on "when I **saw** thou **sawest** my heart" underscores the idea that the speaker and his lady are one in mind, body, and spirit: he wakes to *see* what she's *seeing*, as if he's looking through her supernatural eyes. And the building tension of all those "knew'st"s (especially the intense [anaphora](#) on the phrase "when thou knew'st") leads up to the grand conclusion that it would be "profane" to imagine this lady was anyone but her divine self.

LINES 21-23

Coming and staying show'd thee, thee,

*But rising makes me doubt, that now
Thou art not thou.*

The speaker has just elevated his lady to divinity in a moment of wild, passionate, perhaps manipulative [hyperbole](#). At the beginning of the third stanza, however, there comes a crack in the smooth surface of his waking dream. A note of disillusionment enters the poem as the speaker says, to paraphrase: *When you came to my bedside and stayed there, it proved to me that you were you. But now you're getting up, and that makes me worry that you aren't you.*

The speaker's phrasing here emphasizes the *distance* between the fantasized lady and the real lady:

- When the real lady is doing what the dream lady would, when there's no space between fantasy and reality, there's no space in the language, either. "Thee, thee": the two pronouns mirror each other through tight-knit [epizeuxis](#).
- When the real lady is doing what the dream lady *wouldn't*, the distance shows in the language, where "thou" and "thou" are separated: "**thou** art not **thou**."

The lady appears to the speaker to be truly herself *only when she's behaving like his dream of her*, then. His dream-lady strikes him as truer than the living woman who is currently fixing to leave the room. If a difference appears between the dream-lady and the flesh-lady, then the speaker seems to feel he has no choice but to put his faith in the dream; the dream is closer to the "truth" of his love.

LINES 24-26

*That love is weak, where fear's as strong as he;
'Tis not all spirit, pure, and brave,
If mixture it of fear, shame, honour have.*

If the speaker's dream-lady now seems realer to him than the actual lady before him, the speaker continues, that's simply because he has so lofty an idea of love. "That love is weak where fear's as strong as he," he declares, meaning love should overpower fear handily. And if love is "all spirit, pure, and brave"—if it's a thing of undiluted spiritual purity—then it can't be intermingled with "fear, shame, honour." In other words, a love that can be held back by worries about sexual purity can itself only be an impure love. True love overcomes little quibbles about one's reputation. And this lady, as the speaker has established, is truth itself—so if she were really herself, then she wouldn't be heading toward the door right now.

Such wish-gratifying idealism, the lady might reasonably object, is a bit rich coming from a man. The stakes of sex were very different for men and women in Donne's time. An intense sexual double standard deemed that women should only have sex after marriage, where men could do pretty much what they liked. The consequences for a woman who was known to have

lost her "honour" might be severe.

Once more, then, there are two different layers of meaning at work here:

- The speaker is arguing that a lady "so true" as his beloved should be free to express sexual love that isn't held back by fear, shame, or honor. In one sense, this is a genuinely idealistic view that suggests that intense love is something divine, something that can and should transcend the petty restrictions of a shortsighted world. The speaker wants his lady to join in with him in living out an ideal, "pure" love.
- At the same time, this speaker is trying to persuade an evidently reluctant woman to come to bed with him against her better judgment.

The tension between these positions is clearest in a sly [pun](#) Donne slips in here. "Spirit" could mean the soul, but in English Renaissance slang, it could also mean "semen." The speaker hopes through his love to express at least one of the two—but ideally both.

Besides the question of whether or not this lady is going to come to bed with him, the speaker raises a larger philosophical question. What does "true" mean? Can it be that the eager dream lady is somehow truer than the reluctant lady of waking life, because she's more in tune with a high divine truth about what love is (or could be, or should be)? Or is the speaker's dream running away with him, deluding him into putting all his faith in a fantasy?

For that matter: what does the lady want? All readers know about her is that she has awakened the speaker in his bed, but now appears to be leaving again. Why she arrived and why she's departing—from *her* perspective, at least—is a mystery.

LINES 27-30

*Perchance, as torches which must ready be,
Men light and put out, so thou deal'st with me;
Thou cam'st to kindle, goest to come; then I
Will dream that hope again, but else would die.*

The speaker has established that his lady is most herself when she's behaving like the lady in his dreams. That "true" lady is the one who will "do the rest" of his dream with him, acting out their love to completion. But there's a problem: the living lady appears to be getting up and leaving. He'll have to think quickly to heal this fracture between his dream and his waking life.

And so he does, with the help of a handy [analogy](#). Perhaps, he theorizes, his lady is treating him the same way that people treat torches that "must ready be" (that need to be lit up quickly): they "light and put out" such torches, singing them once and then blowing them out so that they'll light up all the faster the next time they're needed.

With this [simile](#), the speaker justifies his lady's unaccountable

behavior. She must have “cam’st to kindle”—that is, she came to his bedside in order to light him up, [metaphorically](#) speaking, with desire. Now, paradoxically, she “goest to come”: she’s leaving only so that she can come back later and find him *all the more ready* for sex.

It is only in this “hope” of eventual fulfilment that the speaker decides he can go on. He’ll “dream that hope again,” he says—perhaps suggesting that he’ll go back to sleep in the hopes that he might return to his beautiful dream and once more be blissfully awakened from it, this time with more “hope” of “do[ing] the rest.” Otherwise, he says, he might just die.

That’s a [hyperbolic](#) statement of his frustration, but also another sexual pun: to “die,” in Renaissance slang, is to orgasm. In other words: if he didn’t have faith that his true, true lady was going to come back and satisfy him, the whole encounter might as well wrap up now. The speaker remains hanging in between dream and reality, choosing to have faith that his lady is “so true” there’s no way she’s not going to come back and do what she does in his dreams.



POETIC DEVICES

SIMILE

[Similes](#) of light and fire make the speaker’s depictions of passion seem to glow. The first of these similes arrives in the second stanza, where the speaker describes how his beloved woke him from his dream:

As lightning, or a taper’s light,
Thine eyes, and not thy noise, wak’d me;

In this image, the beloved’s gaze has the same power to wake the speaker as a bolt of lightning outside the window—or a lit candle carried into the room. The [juxtaposition](#) of these two kinds of light highlights the difference between them: the white jolt of lightning and the warm, small, constant glow of candlelight create very different moods. The simile thus suggests that both of these lights combine in the beloved’s gaze: the light of her eyes is shocking *and* warm, thrilling *and* comforting, grand *and* intimate. It’s also powerful: a mere look from her is tangible.

Toward the end of the poem, the speaker returns to a firelit simile, but in a very different tone:

Perchance, as torches which must ready be,
Men light and put out, so thou deal’st with me;

Here, the speaker imagines himself as a torch being briefly lit, then blown out so that it could be more easily relit later (as was a common custom in more torch-lit times). This, at least, is what he hopes is going on here. His beloved has entered the room,

awakened him right before the grand finale of his dream, and is now departing again before the couple has had the chance to “do the rest” of the dream. The frustrated speaker can thus only hope that his beloved is quenching his [metaphorical](#) flame now so that he’ll be easier to light up again later on. This simile adds a note of broad comedy to the speaker’s thwarting, deflating his sublimer musings on the divinity of his beloved with a dirty joke. Fire is an old [symbol](#) for passion—and an upright but unlit torch is an unsubtle image of male sexual frustration.

Where Simile appears in the poem:

- **Lines 11-12:** “As lightning, or a taper’s light, / Thine eyes, and not thy noise, wak’d me;”
- **Lines 27-29:** “Perchance, as torches which must ready be, / Men light and put out, so thou deal’st with me; / Thou cam’st to kindle, goest to come;”

REPETITION

[Repetitions](#) play both a theatrical and a thematic role in “The Dream”: they create moments of drama, and they gesture to some of the poem’s most complicated ideas. For example, the speaker uses [anaphora](#) in lines 17-18 to build to a dramatic conclusion:

When thou knew’st what I dreamt, when thou
knew’st when
Excess of joy would wake me, and cam’st then,

This repetition supports the speaker’s urgent point, insisting on the deep significance of what the beloved “knew’st” and when she knew’st it. It’s on this foundation that the speaker will build his grand argument that his beloved is divine above any angel (since no mere angel could have seen into his dream and known precisely what was about to happen in it).

Meanwhile, the [epizeuxis](#) and [diacope](#) of lines 21-23 highlight the poem’s dizzying play with reality and fantasy:

Coming and staying show’d thee, thee,
But rising makes me doubt, that now
Thou art not thou.

A brief paraphrase of these lines might be helpful here: *The fact that you came to my bedside and that you stayed here proved to me that you are really you. But now that you’re getting up, I begin to worry that you aren’t you after all.* The way Donne phrases these lines, with the mirrored “thee, thee” and “thou [...] thou,” draws attention to the strange switch-up that’s happening here:

- When the beloved approaches the speaker, he feels certain that she is herself: the same boundlessly “true” and real figure he saw in his dreams.
- When she withdraws, however, he begins to worry

that *she is not herself*—because the “herself” he knows to be true *from his own dreams* would not back away like that.

The nature of the real lady is at stake here! The speaker’s sense (indeed his dream) of the lady as infinitely, divinely “true” and passionate becomes the standard by which he measures her reality. The repeated “thee” and “thou” underscore the point that there certainly are two “thee”s in the room in every interaction with another person: the version who lives in one’s head and the real, separate person. Part of the glory of the speaker’s love is that he feels sure his dream-woman is identical to the real woman: she’s so “true” she makes “dreams truths,” remember.

Unable to believe that his true lady would leave him hanging, the speaker concludes that she must be frustrating him now just so that he’ll be more eager later. “Thou **cam'st to kindle, goest to come**,” he says, with [parallelism](#) that points to a bit of wish-fulfillment: if the lady has indeed come to wake him only to rile him up, leaving becomes only a prelude to a more satisfying kind of staying, later on. In this way, he preserves the smooth surface of his waking dream even as he goes back to sleep in the hopes of returning to his earlier vision.

Where Repetition appears in the poem:

- **Line 8:** “dreams truths,” “fables histories”
- **Line 10:** “dream,” “dream”
- **Line 15:** “saw,” “sawest”
- **Lines 17-18:** “When thou knew'st what I dreamt, when thou knew'st when / Excess of joy would wake me”
- **Line 20:** “thee,” “thee”
- **Line 21:** “thee, thee”
- **Line 23:** “Thou,” “thou”
- **Line 29:** “cam'st to kindle, goest to come”

PUN

“The Dream,” like many of Donne’s poems, mingles sexuality and divinity, sometimes to the point that there seems to be no division between the two. That intermixture is plainest in Donne’s [puns](#). The first of these turns up in line 25, when the speaker says, assessing the quality of his beloved’s love for him:

‘Tis not all **spirit**, pure, and brave
If mixture it of fear, shame, honour have.

A paraphrase of these lines might run: *Love isn’t all unadulterated and splendid spiritual goodness if it’s mixed up with fear, shame, and worries about your reputation*. That’s an idealistic point, but it’s complicated by the fact that the word “spirit” was also used to mean both “semen” and “an erection” in Donne’s era. (See Shakespeare’s [Sonnet 129](#) for another famous Renaissance “spirit” pun.) Both those meanings have obvious relevance in a

poem about a man awakened the very second before he’s about to come to the climax of an intimate dream. The pun here argues for something “pure, and brave” in the speaker’s physical love as well as the beloved’s.

When the beloved, apparently unconvinced, withdraws from the speaker’s bedroom, the speaker consoles himself with the thought that she might just be trying to frustrate him *now* so it’ll be easier to excite him again *later*. With that in mind, he retires to his bed to “dream that hope again, but else would die.” In other words, he’s going to try to return to his glorious dream of his beloved—because otherwise, he’d just die right there. Yes, “die” is also a pun: in Renaissance slang, to die was to reach sexual climax. (It makes sense: one’s “spirit” is released in both cases!) The poem thus ends with the speaker in a state of terrible sexual frustration, unwilling to give up on his dream, but also unwilling to let it come to its natural conclusion in case his beloved is planning to make a return visit later on.

Where Pun appears in the poem:

- **Lines 25-26:** “‘Tis not all spirit, pure, and brave, / If mixture it of fear, shame, honour have.”
- **Lines 29-30:** “then I / Will dream that hope again, but else would die.”

HYPERBOLE

To fully understand the audacious [hyperbole](#) Donne deploys in this poem, readers need to know a little about Renaissance theology. In this poem, Donne’s speaker doesn’t merely say his beloved is an angel. Rather, he says she must be *higher* than an angel, and he builds that point on the back of an [allusion](#) to the arguments of an influential medieval theologian.

When the speaker’s beloved first woke him up, he says, he was sure for a second that she was an angel. But that doesn’t quite track, because she must have been able to read his thoughts in order to awaken him when she did: at the exact moment before his dream reached its conclusion. To do so, the speaker says, is “beyond an Angel’s art.”

This point is taken from the angelology of the medieval theologian Thomas Aquinas. Aquinas (whose scholarly examinations of Christian doctrine deeply influenced all Christian thought after him) argued that angels don’t have the power to see into human hearts or read human minds. Only God can do that.

If the speaker’s beloved can do what angels can’t, then she’s playing the role of no one less than God here, a point the speaker underscores when he says it would be “profane” (or sacrilegious) of him to think that she was anyone *but* who she is. She’s taken on divine power at the very least—and all in the name of averting untimely nocturnal emissions.

This wildly hyperbolic claim is at once obviously comical and

deadly serious. Throughout this poem, the speaker says that his love for his lady makes her realer than real to him, truer than true. In this, she has taken on divinity: she's as fundamentally *true* to the speaker as God is.

Where Hyperbole appears in the poem:

- **Lines 11-20:** "As lightning, or a taper's light, / Thine eyes, and not thy noise, wak'd me; / Yet I thought thee / (For thou lovest truth) an angel, at first sight; / But when I saw thou sawest my heart, / And knew'st my thoughts, beyond an angel's art, / When thou knew'st what I dreamt, when thou knew'st when / Excess of joy would wake me, and cam'st then, / I must confess, it could not choose but be / Profane, to think thee anything but thee."

ENJAMBMENT

[Enjambments](#) help to create moments of drama, setting off some of the speaker's more daring ideas. A couple of good examples appear in lines 17-20:

When thou knew'st what I dreamt, when thou
knew'st **when**
Excess of joy would wake me, and cam'st then,
I must confess, it could not choose but **be**
Profane, to think thee anything but thee.

The first of these enjambments creates a delicate pause before the words "excess of joy"—a euphemistic way to describe an orgasm. That pause mirrors exactly what the speaker describes: an *interruption*, one that arrives right before the momentum of his dream can bring that dream's action to an end.

The next enjambment, meanwhile, sets off a big claim: that it would be "profane," sacrilegious, to mistake the beloved for anyone but herself, even for an angel. That's because (what the speaker sees as) her power to know the exact moment she should interrupt his dream reveals that she's even higher and holier than the angels: she's displaying a godlike power of mind-reading here. The enjambment adds special stress to this moment of comical (yet also serious) [hyperbole](#).

When the lady begins to get up and leave the speaker's bedroom, another enjambment creates a tone of high drama:

But rising makes me doubt, that **now**
Thou art not thou.

Supported by the [internal rhyme](#) of "now" and "thou," this enjambment shines a spotlight on the idea that the lady *isn't herself* because she's doing something that (in the speaker's opinion) she'd *never* do: leaving him sexually frustrated.

Where Enjambment appears in the poem:

- **Lines 1-2:** "thee / Would"
- **Lines 3-4:** "theme / For"
- **Lines 5-6:** "yet / My"
- **Lines 7-8:** "suffice / To"
- **Lines 13-14:** "thee / (For"
- **Lines 17-18:** "when / Excess"
- **Lines 19-20:** "be / Profane"
- **Lines 22-23:** "now / Thou"
- **Lines 29-30:** "I / Will"



VOCABULARY

Thee, thou, thy, thine (Line 1, Line 5, Line 6, Line 7, Line 9, Line 12, Line 13, Line 15, Line 17, Line 20, Line 21, Line 23, Line 28, Line 29) - Old-fashioned ways of saying "you" and "your":

- "Thou" is the subject form of "you," as in "Thou art so true"
- "Thee" is the object form, as in "I thought thee an angel"
- "Thy" and "thine" both mean "your"; "thine" appears before words that start with a vowel sound (as in "Thine eyes")

Note that "**thou**" is cognate with the French, Italian, or Spanish "**tu**": it's an intimate or informal way of addressing someone.

Reason (Line 4) - "Reason" here means something like "waking thought": the idea is that the speaker's dream was so persuasive and realistic he felt as if it were really happening.

Wak'dst (Line 5) - A contraction of "wakedst," meaning "awakened."

Brok'st (Line 6) - A contraction of "brokest," meaning "broke." (Note that similar contractions appear throughout the poem: "knew'st" means "knew," "cam'st" means "came," and so on.)

True (Line 7) - The word "true" here has a special meaning: the speaker is saying that his beloved is realer than real. Her existence has some extra force for him; she seems to *exist* differently than other people do.

Suffice (Line 7) - Are enough.

Histories (Line 8) - True stories.

Taper (Line 11) - A candle.

An angel's art (Line 16) - An angel's powers. According to the influential medieval theologian Thomas Aquinas, angels did not have the power to read human hearts and minds—and that's precisely what the speaker suggests his beloved can do here.

Excess of joy would wake me (Line 18) - The speaker here euphemistically describes his beloved interrupting his intimate dream before it could reach its conclusion: ejaculation.

It could not choose to be profane (Lines 19-20) - That is, "It could only be sacrilegious."

Rising (Line 22) - Getting out of bed again.

Doubt (Line 22) - Worry, fear.

Spirit (Line 25) - There's a [pun](#) here. Aside from meaning the soul, "spirit," in Donne's time, could suggest both semen and an erection.

Pure, and brave (Line 25) - Unadulterated and glorious. ("Brave," in Donne's time, was a broader term of praise, meaning more than just "courageous"; compare Miranda's "[O brave new world](#)! That has such people in't" in Shakespeare's [The Tempest](#).)

Perchance (Line 27) - Maybe, perhaps.

Torches (Line 27) - Donne here alludes to the practice of seasoning a torch: lighting it for just long enough to blacken it, then putting it out again. Lighting it once would make it faster to ignite when it was actually needed.

Kindle (Line 29) - Light on fire.

Die (Line 30) - Another sexual [pun](#). To "die," in Renaissance slang, meant to have an orgasm.

true lovers aren't worried by little things like "fear," "shame," and "honour."

As many of Donne's poems do, then, "The Dream" makes a more profound case for sexual love than "It's fun and life is short." To this speaker, such love can even embody something divine.

METER

The English Romantic poet [Samuel Taylor Coleridge](#) once wrote that Donne's poetic muse "[on dromedary trots](#)": in other words, Donne's verse has the bumpy, surprising rhythms of a ride on camelback. That's certainly true of the [meter](#) in "The Dream," which is as complex as Donne's thought.

This poem uses a mixture of [iambic](#) meters: that is, its lines are built from iambs, metrical feet with a da-DUM rhythm, as in "perchance" or "profane." Here's how the rhythm of each stanza runs:

- The first two lines use iambic tetrameter: a line of four iambs, as in "Dear love, | for noth- | ing less | than thee"
- The third line uses iambic dimeter: a line of two iambs, as in "It was | a theme"
- The fourth line uses iambic pentameter: a line of five iambs, as in "That love | is weak | where fear's | as strong | as he"
- The fifth line uses iambic tetrameter again, as in "'Tis not | all spir- | it, pure, | and brave"
- And the remaining five lines of the stanza return to iambic pentameter.

The opening lines of each stanza, then, flicker like a candle flame, darting from long to short and back; the closing lines take on a steadier and more predictable rhythm, like a heartbeat. (Not *fully* predictable, of course. Donne often introduces a [trochee](#)—the opposite foot to an iamb, with a DUM-da rhythm—into his iambic lines, as in "Enter | these arms.")

This pattern follows the action and mood of the poem: there's a repeated rhythm of build, urgency, and withdrawal that suggests the speaker's excitement (and frustration) as he awakes to find his dream true—but not quite as true as he'd like.

RHYME SCHEME

The basic [rhyme scheme](#) of each of this poem's stanzas runs like this:

ABBACCDDEE

The stanzas, in other words, start out with an enfolding ABBA rhyme pattern, then resolve into a string of three [couplets](#).

Listen to the whole poem, however, and that reliable pattern becomes more complex. Donne reuses certain rhymes across



FORM, METER, & RHYME

FORM

John Donne invents his own poetic form here, as he often did. The poem is built from three ten-line stanzas, each of which begins with five lines of varying length and ends in five lines of regular iambic pentameter (that is, lines of five [iambs](#), metrical feet with a da-DUM rhythm, as in "Thou art | so true | that thoughts | of thee | suffice"). Each stanza thus starts out wavering and ends with a more regular pulse.

That division maps onto the poem's action, in which the speaker—lost in an intimate dream of his beloved—awakes to find that she's right there, then tries to persuade her to help him finish what the dream started. The flickering rhythms of the first part of each stanza move into the regularity of the second part as dream segues into waking. The poem's changing rhythms also mirror the poem's theme of building sexual tension, moving from a weaving dance into a more propulsive, urgent, regular pulse.

In its coaxing tone, this poem has something in common with *carpe diem* poems like Marvell's "[To His Coy Mistress](#)" and Herrick's "[To the Virgins, to Make Much of Time](#)." However, where such poems' speakers try to talk ladies into bed by reminding them that life is short and they should have fun while they can, this poem's speaker makes a bolder case. His lady should sleep with him, he argues, because:

- His dream of her was so real that it's as if it's already happened—so why hold back?
- He knows she's a true and courageous lover, and

the poem: the long /ee/ of "be," "thee," "me," "he," and "fantasy" returns in every stanza. Mapping out the whole rhyme scheme looks like this:

ABBACCDDEE FAAFGGHHAA AIIAJJAAKK

This rhyme scheme might look confusing on the page, but the basic pattern is always consistent—and the return and return of the A rhyme, that long /ee/ sound, feels harmoniously intense. That's especially true because so many of the A rhymes are also identical rhymes on just three words: "me," "thee," and "be." (The only variants are the "he" of line 24 and the "fantasy" of line 4.) The recurrent A rhyme thus keeps the poem's central players—the lover, the beloved, and the nature of reality—at center stage.



SPEAKER

The speaker of this poem is a lot like the speaker of many of Donne's poems: he's a passionate lover with a brilliant intellect, and he's trying to use the latter quality in the service of the former. Here, more specifically, he's applying his powerful brain to the cause of flattery, trying to sweet-talk his beloved into hopping into bed with him to "do the rest" of the intimate dream she's just awakened him from.

In making his case, he blurs the boundaries between dream and truth, human and divine. When his lady wakes him up, he tells her that she's so profoundly *true*, so deeply *real*, that a dream of her *is* real. She literally makes his dreams come true. This [cliché](#) is no cliché here, but something deeper and more metaphysical: love makes this lady the truest thing in the world to the speaker, something realer than reality. Of course, this idea also serves a sneaky secondary purpose. If there's no difference between the dream-lady and the real lady, then they're already midway through having sex, and there's no point in the real lady refusing to finish what she began!

In another elaborate bit of flattery, the speaker tells his lady that when he first woke up, he thought she must be an angel—then realized that she couldn't be a mere angel. That's because, according to the theology of the great medieval thinker Thomas Aquinas (with whom Donne agreed on this point), angels can't read thoughts. This lady can: she has clearly seen right into the speaker's mind to wake him up at the precise moment before his dream reaches its climax. In so saying, the speaker implies that his lady has not an angel's powers but *God's*. Renaissance theology held that only God could see into the human mind and heart. At the very least, then, the lady's powers of knowing exactly the moment to interrupt his dream are *god-like*.

Heady praise in which sexual love touches the divine, an undercurrent of tongue-in-cheek coaxing: these qualities are hallmarks of Donne's verse, and the reader would be well within their rights to read this silver-tongued theologian/

seducer as Donne himself.



SETTING

The poem takes place in its speaker's bed—a place where he's just been having a very pleasant dream only to be awakened by the even more pleasant presence of the lady he was dreaming about. A more specific setting only reveals itself through the speaker's allusions to lighting and to theology. His mention that a "taper's light" (that is, candlelight) can wake someone up, his awareness that people sometimes "light and put out" torches so that they're faster to light again later, and his acquaintance with the angelology of Thomas Aquinas all suggest that he lives in John Donne's own world: England around the turn of the 17th century, a world lit by open flame and by baroque theological theorizing.

The poem also places itself through its mention of the different sexual standards for men and women. This poem's speaker (like many speakers before and since) is doing his best to coax an apparently reluctant lady into bed with him in spite of the fact that "fear, shame, honour" might all hold her back. Fear, shame, and honor were all greater sexual concerns for 17th-century Englishwomen than for 17th-century Englishmen: women were expected to remain chaste until marriage, and the consequences for not doing so could be severe.



CONTEXT

LITERARY CONTEXT

John Donne (1572-1631) is remembered as one of the foremost of the "metaphysical poets"—though he never called himself one. The later writer [Samuel Johnson](#) coined the term, using it to describe a set of 17th-century English writers who wrote witty, passionate, intricate, cerebral poetry about love and God; [George Herbert](#), [Andrew Marvell](#), and [Thomas Traherne](#) were some others.

Donne was the prototypical metaphysical poet: a master of elaborate [conceits](#) and complex sentences, a great writer of love poems (like this one) that mingle images of holiness with filthy [puns](#). But during his lifetime, he was mostly a poet in private. In public life, he was an important clergyman, rising to become Dean of St. Paul's Cathedral in London. Like the vast majority of his poetry, "The Dream" didn't appear in print until several years after his death in 1633, when his collection *Poems* was posthumously published.

Donne's mixture of cynicism, passion, and mysticism fell out of literary favor after his 17th-century heyday; Johnson, for instance, a leading figure of the 18th-century Enlightenment, did not mean "metaphysical poet" as a compliment, seeing Donne and his contemporaries as obscure and irrational. But

19th-century Romantic poets like [Samuel Taylor Coleridge](#) were stirred by Donne's mixture of philosophy and emotion, and their enthusiasm slowly resurrected Donne's reputation. Donne is now remembered as one of the most powerful and influential of poets, and he's inspired later writers from [T. S. Eliot](#) to [Yeats](#) to A. S. Byatt.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT

John Donne was a notorious ladies' man who would, over the course of his life, amass plenty of experience [breaking hearts](#) and [having his heart broken](#). His sometimes foolhardy decision-making around women came to a head in an oddly touching way: when he fell deeply in love with Anne More, an important official's daughter, he eloped with her without getting her family's permission. This romantic leap of faith backfired on him when his wife's angry father had him thrown in prison.

While Donne was eventually reconciled with his father-in-law, this was a rocky beginning to a marriage that would see many difficulties. The Donnes and their many children lived in relative poverty. In order to stay financially afloat, Donne was forced to be literally afloat: he sailed on endless business trips all over Europe, and was often away from home for long stretches of time. Many of his passionate love poems tell the story of [tearful farewells](#).

It was while Donne was away on one of his many business trips that tragedy struck: Anne Donne died giving birth to a stillborn child in 1617. The heartbroken Donne turned to his religious faith for consolation—and to support his surviving children. Under the patronage of King James I, he became a prominent and successful Anglican clergyman, the Dean of St. Paul's Cathedral in London. In that capacity, he wrote devotional verse [every bit as passionate](#) as his love poetry.

- [A Short Biography](#) — Read the Poetry Foundation's brief biography of Donne to learn more about his life and work. (<https://www.poetryfoundation.org/poets/john-donne>)
- [Donne's Legacy](#) — Read a review of a recent Donne biography to learn a little about how contemporary scholars approach Donne. (<https://www.theguardian.com/books/2022/apr/10/super-infinite-the-transformations-of-john-donne-review-masterly-study>)

LITCHARTS ON OTHER JOHN DONNE POEMS

- [A Hymn to God the Father](#)
- [Air and Angels](#)
- [A Valediction: Forbidding Mourning](#)
- [A Valediction: Of Weeping](#)
- [Elegy V: His Picture](#)
- [Holy Sonnet 10: Death, be not proud](#)
- [Holy Sonnet 14: Batter my heart, three-person'd God](#)
- [Holy Sonnet 1: Thou hast made me, and shall thy work decay?](#)
- [Holy Sonnet 6: This is my play's last scene](#)
- [Holy Sonnet 7: At the round earth's imagined corners](#)
- [Hymn to God My God, in My Sickness](#)
- [No Man Is an Island](#)
- [Song: Go and catch a falling star](#)
- [The Apparition](#)
- [The Canonization](#)
- [The Flea](#)
- [The Good-Morrow](#)
- [The Relic](#)
- [The Sun Rising](#)
- [The Triple Fool](#)
- [To His Mistress Going to Bed](#)



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MORE RESOURCES

EXTERNAL RESOURCES

- [The Poem Aloud](#) — Listen to a reading of the poem (performed in scholars' best approximation of what Donne's 17th-century accent would have sounded like). (<https://youtu.be/X0N0Ow6rRuU?si=vDDIB55nmTVolzPt>)
- [A Portrait of Donne](#) — Admire a portrait of the young Donne in which he poses as the very model of a melancholy Renaissance lover. (<https://www.npg.org.uk/collections/search/portrait/mw111844/John-Donne>)